

[*Link to Spanish Application](#)

[Aplicación en español aquí.](#)



FY26 Equity Mini Grant Program Playbook

Austin Equity & Inclusion, Equity Division

Funding Focus:

Immigrant & Refugee Services

Program Year:

FY2025-2026

Funding Source:

City of Austin General Fund

Tagline:

“Supporting community-based efforts that strengthen economic mobility and expand opportunities to thrive.”

Table of Contents

1. About the Program	3
2. FY26 Funding Focus: Immigrant and Refugee Services	5
3. Eligibility.....	8
4. Award Structure.....	13
5. Timeline.....	14
6. Awardee Expectations.....	15
7. Application Support.....	17
8. Application Overview.....	18
9. Application Questions.....	19
10. Scoring Rubric and Review Process.....	28
11. Reviewer Guidance.....	37
12. Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs).....	39

About the Program

History and Institutional Context

The Equity Mini Grant Program was established in 2018 under the City of Austin’s Equity Office as a flexible funding opportunity to support community-led efforts addressing disparities in quality of life across Austin. Since its inception, the program has invested in a wide range of initiatives—including public health, homelessness response, re-entry services, housing stability, community safety, and immigrant inclusion—reflecting the evolving needs and priorities of Austin’s communities.

As of October 2024, Austin Equity & Inclusion, structure brings together Equity, Civil Rights, and a newly established Human Rights division under a unified framework. Within this structure, the Equity Division continues to focus on identifying service gaps, improving access to resources, and supporting community-informed solutions that strengthen quality of life for residents. This transition aligns with the City’s broader direction under the leadership of City Manager T.C. Broadnax, which emphasizes coordinated service delivery, measurable outcomes, and strengthened alignment across departments.

Program Purpose

The Equity Mini Grant Program provides funding to support community-based efforts that expand access to services, strengthen community connections, and address barriers that affect quality of life for Austin residents. The program is designed to invest in grassroots and community-rooted work that may not always have access to traditional funding opportunities, while advancing the City’s commitment to effective, responsive, and inclusive service delivery.

This funding opportunity prioritizes smaller organizations, grassroots groups, and community-led initiatives that are closely connected to the communities they serve. These organizations often play a critical role in building trust, identifying unmet needs, and delivering services in ways that are accessible and culturally responsive.

In addition to supporting community-based work, the program is intended to serve as an entry point for organizations that may be less familiar with City funding processes. Through participation, applicants gain experience navigating vendor registration, contracting requirements, and grant administration expectations. This approach helps build

organizational readiness over time and expands access to future City funding opportunities, supporting a broader and more inclusive network of community partners.

For Fiscal Year 2026, the program focuses on supporting immigrant and refugee communities in Austin, Travis County, and the City's Extraterritorial Jurisdiction (ETJ). This focus reflects the City's recognition of the important role these communities play in Austin's social, cultural, and economic life, as well as the need to strengthen access points, reduce barriers, and improve connection to services and opportunities.

Through this funding, the City seeks to support community-based efforts that strengthen trust, expand access to services, and create pathways for long-term stability and economic mobility. Projects funded through this program may contribute to a range of outcomes, including improved access to essential services, increased community connection, and expanded opportunities for residents to achieve stability and thrive over time.

FY26 Funding Focus: Immigrant and Refugee Services

Why This Focus Area Matters

For the purposes of this program, the term "immigrant" is used broadly to include individuals with a wide range of immigration experiences and statuses, including but not limited to refugees, asylees, asylum seekers, parolees, lawful permanent residents, visa holders, undocumented individuals, and others navigating varied immigration pathways.

Immigrant and refugee communities are essential to the social, cultural, and economic fabric of Austin. Immigrants contribute to the city's neighborhoods, schools, workforce, and community life while often navigating systems that can create barriers to accessing services, resources, and opportunities.

These barriers may include language access challenges, limited familiarity with institutional systems, gaps in service delivery, or other conditions that affect access to housing, healthcare, education, employment, economic mobility, and civic participation. Addressing these challenges requires community-based approaches that are rooted in trust, cultural knowledge, and lived experience.

What This Program Seeks to Support

For Fiscal Year 2026, the Equity Mini Grant Program supports community-based efforts that serve immigrant and refugee communities in Austin, Travis County, and the City's Extraterritorial Jurisdiction (ETJ).

This funding prioritizes work that:

- strengthens belonging and trust between communities and service providers;
- expands access to essential services, resources, and necessities of daily life;
- reduces barriers that limit participation in community and civic life; and
- improves conditions that support stability, opportunity, connection, and quality of life.

Projects may focus on a single community or may bring together multiple immigrant or refugee communities across Austin. The program recognizes that community leadership, cultural knowledge, and lived experience are essential forms of expertise in addressing complex challenges and strengthening community stability and opportunity.

This funding priority aligns with the City Manager's focus on People, Place, Partnerships, and Performance by supporting community-driven solutions that strengthen belonging, expand access to essential services and necessities of daily life, and build durable partnerships that improve quality of life and economic opportunity for Austin residents.

Integrating Economic Mobility

Economic mobility is not a separate funding category within this program. Instead, it is one of several long-term outcomes that may result from improving access, reducing barriers, and strengthening community conditions.

As defined by the City of Austin:

“Economic mobility addresses systems to improve unfair conditions that influence whether individuals, families, and communities can prosper over time and across generations. It means access to opportunities and resources needed for basic needs, financial security, and a dignified, high quality of life – regardless of race, place, gender, or ability.”

Projects funded through this priority area may contribute to economic mobility by helping residents:

- meet basic needs and achieve greater stability;
- access employment, education, or income-generating opportunities;
- navigate systems that affect financial security and long-term wellbeing.

Applicants are not required to use specific City frameworks or terminology. However, strong applications will clearly describe how their work improves access to services, reduces barriers, or strengthens conditions that support residents’ ability to thrive over time.

Types of Projects Supported

Projects may focus on a single immigrant community or may bring together multiple immigrant or refugee communities across Austin. The program recognizes that community leadership, cultural knowledge, and lived experience are essential forms of expertise in addressing complex social challenges and strengthening community stability and opportunity. Work funded under this priority area may include — but are not limited to — efforts such as:

- Community-building and mutual support programs that strengthen belonging and community resilience.
- ESL education, citizenship support, language access or system navigation assistance.

- Leadership development, workforce readiness, and economic mobility initiatives.
- Cultural organizing and intergenerational connection activities that strengthen cultural identity and community ties, such as maintaining heritage languages.
- Creative projects that bring diverse immigrant communities together through arts, storytelling, or shared cultural activities.
- Outreach, language access, or community education efforts that improve awareness of and access to essential services.
- Programs that help immigrant families navigate services, systems, and opportunities related to housing, education, health, employment, and other necessities of daily life.

All proposed projects should clearly describe:

- The barrier or challenge being addressed; and
- How the proposed work improves access, stability, or opportunity for the community served.

Projects Not Supported

Projects that do not clearly demonstrate a connection to improving access, reducing barriers, or strengthening conditions that affect community stability and opportunity may not be competitive under this priority area.

In general, projects that fall outside the scope of this program include:

- Activities that do not demonstrate a clear connection to community access, stability, or opportunity.
- Projects that primarily serve internal organizational needs rather than community benefit.
- Activities that substantially duplicate existing City services without demonstrating a clear community-based approach, added value, or how the work complements or connects to existing efforts.

Eligibility

The Equity Mini Grant Program is designed to support a wide range of community-based organizations and initiatives while ensuring that funded projects can be successfully implemented within the City of Austin's funding and contracting requirements.

Geographic Eligibility

Funded activities must primarily serve residents within:

- the City of Austin
- Travis County
- or the City of Austin's Extraterritorial Jurisdiction (ETJ)*

* The ETJ is the unincorporated land within five miles of Austin's boundary that is not within the city limits. This funding originates from the City of Austin's General Fund; therefore, projects must demonstrate a clear benefit to residents within this geographic area. Applicants should be able to describe how their work directly serves communities located within these boundaries.

Eligible Applicants

The Equity Mini Grant Program prioritizes work led by or in strong partnership with immigrant and refugee communities. Organizations do not need to be large or professionally staffed to apply. The program intentionally supports community-rooted work that may not always have access to traditional grant funding. The City values lived experience, cultural knowledge, and trusted community relationships as important forms of leadership. Applicants without nonprofit status must apply through a fiscal sponsor or as an individual vendor registered with the City of Austin, in accordance with City vendor requirements. Applicants may include:

- Small local nonprofit organizations;
- Community or faith-based organizations and community groups;
- Grassroots organizations and community alliances;
- Neighborhood groups and coalitions;
- Student groups and community collectives;
- For-profit entities engaged in community-serving work;

- Individuals working with fiscal sponsors;
- Individuals able to register as a vendor with the City of Austin.

The program intentionally welcomes a variety of applicants, including volunteer-led groups, emerging organizations, informal community networks, and culturally specific initiatives. As part of the evaluation process, applications are assessed based on demonstrated connections to the communities served and a clear understanding of community needs.

Funding Preference for Smaller Organizations

This program is designed to expand access to City funding for organizations that may not have consistent or sustained financial support.

- Organizations with annual operating budgets of **\$500,000 or less** are strongly encouraged to apply
- Organizations with larger budgets may still apply and will be considered

Preference may be given to smaller, grassroots, or emerging organizations in recognition that they often face greater barriers to accessing public funding, despite playing a critical role in community-based service delivery, outreach, and trust-building.

One Application per Applicant

Each organization or individual may submit **one application** under this funding cycle. This limitation is intended to:

- ensure a fair and equitable review process;
- allow for broader distribution of funding across applicants;
- encourage applicants to prioritize their most impactful or well-developed proposal.

If multiple applications are submitted, the City may request that the applicant select one for consideration. Exceptions are allowed for organizations who serve as fiscal sponsors for various community-based initiatives.

Vendor Registration and Contract Readiness

To receive funding, all selected applicants must be able to enter into a contract with the City of Austin. This requires registration as a City of Austin vendor; **or** partnership with a fiscal sponsor that is registered as a City vendor.

Vendor registration is a standard requirement for all City contracts and is not limited to nonprofit organizations. Applicants are strongly encouraged to begin the registration process at time of application (or as early as possible) to avoid delays. Vendor registration can be completed through the City's Austin Finance Online system.

- Registering as a vendor with the City of Austin is a straightforward process that you can complete on the Austin Finance Online Website here:
<https://www.austintexas.gov/service/register-vendor-city>
- Step-by-step instructions for vendor registration can be found here:
<https://assets.austintexas.gov/purchase/downloads/How%20to%20Register%20as%20a%20Vendor.pdf>
- Explore vendor services, manage your vendor account, find and respond to solicitations, review contracts, and learn how to do business with the City of Austin here: <https://www.austintexas.gov/page/vendor-services>
 - *Please note that the physical address you provide at the time of registration is the address to which the physical paper check for the grant-awarded funds will be mailed via USPS.
 - * If you want grant funds distributed via direct deposit (instead of a physical paper check), the City of Austin's preferred electronic payment method for vendors is the Electronic Funds Transfer system via the Automated Clearing House (ACH). To register, please email an ACH registration request to vendor@austintexas.gov.
- For more information or assistance, call the City's Vendor Hotline at 512-974-2018 or email them at vendor@austintexas.gov

Applicants should also be aware that vendor registration and contracting must be completed within a compressed timeframe for this year's program; delays in registration or documentation may impact the ability to receive funding; and failure to complete required steps may result in forfeiture of the award. Timely responsiveness is essential to ensure contracts can be executed within required deadlines. Selected applicants must be prepared to move quickly following award notification. This includes:

- completing vendor registration (if not already complete);
- confirming fiscal sponsor readiness (if applicable);
- collaborating with City staff to finalize the project scope of work.

Fiscal Sponsor Requirement (if applicable)

Applicants who do not have nonprofit status may apply using a fiscal sponsor. A fiscal sponsor is a tax-exempt organization that agrees to receive and manage funds on behalf of another group or initiative. In this arrangement the fiscal sponsor serves as the contracting entity, receives and manages the funds, and assumes responsibility for compliance with City requirements.

Who needs a fiscal sponsor? A fiscal sponsor is required if the applicant does not have nonprofit status and/or is not able or does not wish to register as a vendor with the City as an organization or individual. Applicants who are unsure whether they need a fiscal sponsor are encouraged to review the contracting appendix and/or contact equity@austintexas.gov.

Applicants using a fiscal sponsor must identify the fiscal sponsor at the time of application and ensure they register as a vendor with the City. The fiscal sponsor then becomes responsible for:

- entering into a contract with the City of Austin;
- receiving and managing grant funds;
- complying with City contracting and financial requirements; and
- distributing funds to the applicant in accordance with their agreement.

Fiscal sponsorship is intended to support applicants who may not have the administrative infrastructure to contract directly with the City. Applicants should maintain clear communication with their fiscal sponsor regarding roles, responsibilities, and expectations. Sponsor readiness is also critical. Delays or gaps in fiscal sponsor capacity may affect the ability to complete contracting within required timelines. Applications that do not identify a fiscal sponsor when one is required may be deemed ineligible and forfeit the grant award.

Individual Applicants (Vendor Pathway)

This pathway is intended to support community-based work led by individuals, organizers, and informal initiatives. Individuals may contract directly with the City if they complete vendor registration. Applicants choosing this pathway should be aware that:

- funds will be issued as **taxable income (1099)**;
- individuals are responsible for managing the associated tax obligation;

- individuals must complete all contracting and invoicing requirements.

City Vendor Support

For assistance with vendor registration or contracting requirements, applicants may contact:

- **City of Austin Vendor Services**
- Phone: 512-974-2018
- Email: vendor@austintexas.gov

Bonus: First-Time City Funding

Applicants who have not previously received funding or contracts from the City of Austin will receive +15 bonus points during the scoring process.

This bonus is intended to:

- expand access to City funding opportunities;
- support new and emerging organizations; and
- build long-term capacity for community partners to successfully navigate City contracting and funding processes.

By prioritizing first-time applicants, the program seeks to bring new organizations into the City's funding ecosystem and create pathways for future participation in public funding opportunities.

Award Structure

The Equity Mini Grant Program will provide one-time grant awards of **\$25,000** to selected applicants under the FY26 funding cycle.

Funding is intended to support community-based projects that expand access to services, reduce barriers, and strengthen conditions that support stability, opportunity, and quality of life for immigrant and refugee communities.

Key Elements of the Award Structure

- *Fixed Award Amount:* Each selected applicant will receive a single \$25,000 grant award.
- *Multiple Awards:* Multiple grants will be awarded through a competitive review process. The number of awards will depend on available funding, application quality, and alignment with program priorities.
- *Use of Funds:* Grant funds may be used to support a range of project-related expenses, including program delivery, outreach, direct assistance, mutual aid, operational support, events, supplies, translation, and other costs necessary to carry out community-based work.
- *Competitive Selection Process:* All applications will be evaluated using a standardized scoring rubric and independent review process. Final funding decisions are based on application scores, leadership review, and review panelist recommendations.
- *Funding Source:* Grant funds are provided through the City of Austin's FY26 General Fund.

Relationship to City Priorities

Projects funded through this program may contribute to a range of outcomes, including improved access to services, stronger community connections, and expanded pathways to stability and opportunity. These outcomes align with the City's broader goals of improving quality of life, strengthening service delivery, and supporting conditions that enable long-term economic mobility.

Timeline

The FY26 Equity Mini Grant Program operates on an extremely compressed timeline to align with City leadership directives and fiscal year requirements.

Application Launch and Access:

- The application is expected to open April 17th, 2026.
- Outreach will include information sessions and community engagement that will run parallel to the 3-week application window.

- Office hours by appointment and applicant support will be available throughout the application period. Please contact equity@austintexas.gov to book a consultation.

Application Window

- Applications will remain open until May 8, 2026
- Applications will be reviewed on a **rolling basis**.
- Request for extensions to the deadline will be considered upon request. Please contact equity@austintexas.gov.

Review and Selection Process

- Applications will be evaluated by a review panel using a standard scoring rubric.
- Reviewers will complete independent scoring followed by a facilitated panel approval of recommendations for award.
- Final award decisions are expected in **June 2026**, with notifications issued shortly thereafter.

Contracting and Vendor Readiness

- All applicants must complete vendor registration and fiscal sponsorship verification (if applicable) by June 1st, 2026.
- Selected awardees must be prepared to complete contracting requirements (including refining scope of work) immediately following award notification.
- Delays in vendor registration, fiscal sponsor readiness, or required documentation may impact the ability to complete contracting.
- Contracting is expected to occur in July 2026.
- All contracts must be entered by City staff into the City's internal eCAPRIS system by: **July 31, 2026 (firm deadline)**.
- Contracts submitted after this date cannot be processed.

Implementation Window

Following contract execution, awardees will have an estimated **12–15-month period** to complete project activities and submit final reporting. This approach reflects a trust-based grantmaking model that:

- supports community organizations in planning and delivering work responsibly;
- allows time for relationship-centered engagement and adaptation, and;
- aligns grant timelines with the realities of community-based implementation.

To support timely implementation, awardees will be asked to submit an initial invoice following contract execution. Payment will be processed in alignment with City procedures, enabling organizations to begin project activities without delay.

Key Considerations for Applicants

Applicants should carefully consider the following when applying:

- Vendor Readiness: Early registration is strongly encouraged.
- Fiscal Sponsor Readiness: Sponsors must be identified/prepared ASAP.
- Project Scope: Proposed work should be achievable within the defined implementation window.
- Responsiveness: Timely communication will be required during contracting and onboarding.

Awardee Expectations

Organizations selected for funding through the FY26 Equity Mini Grant Program are expected to carry out their proposed work in a timely, responsible, and community-centered manner. The expectations below are designed to support clear communication and shared learning between awardees and the City.

Communication and Responsiveness

Clear communication is essential to ensure projects remain on track and aligned with program requirements. Awardees are expected to:

- maintain timely and responsive communication with City staff;
- notify staff of any significant changes to project scope, timeline, or leadership;
- respond to requests for information or updates as needed.

Program Orientation and Onboarding

This process is intended to ensure that awardees are prepared to begin implementation following contract execution. Awardees will be required to participate in an initial onboarding process, which may include (but is not limited to):

- review of contract requirements and finalizing scope of work;
- guidance on invoicing and payment procedures;
- overview of reporting expectations;
- introduction to program contacts and support resources.

Project Implementation

Projects should remain responsive to community needs while maintaining alignment with the overall intent of the proposed work. Awardees are expected to:

- carry out the project as described in the approved scope of work;
- implement activities within the agreed-upon timeline;
- document how funds were used and reflect on project outcomes in the final report;
- gather and consider feedback from participants or community members, where appropriate, to inform understanding of the project's impact.

Reporting and Reflection

Awardees will be required to complete a final report. Format is primarily written but can also submitted as be audio/video content, where appropriate. The report must include:

- a summary of activities completed;
- reflections on outcomes, number individuals served and community impact;
- description of how funds were used;
- lessons learned or challenges encountered.

Check-ins and Engagement

These engagements are intended to support project success and foster shared learning across funded organizations. Awardees may be asked to participate in:

- periodic check-ins with City staff;
- site visits or virtual meetings;
- optional learning or information-sharing opportunities.

Support and Technical Assistance

City staff will provide guidance or technical assistance throughout the project period, particularly related to:

- contracting and invoicing processes;
- reporting expectations;
- general program support;

Application Support

Applicants are encouraged to begin preparing early, particularly if translation, fiscal sponsorship, or vendor registration support is needed. Early engagement is encouraged to ensure applicants have sufficient time to access available support. The program offers ongoing support throughout the application period, including virtual office hours and one-on-one consultations. Applicants may request a meeting by emailing equity@austintexas.gov with a few available times, and staff will make every effort to accommodate meetings by phone, Zoom, or in person.

- The program will also host the following virtual information sessions:
- Saturday, April 25, 2026 (1:30–3:00 PM) ([Zoom link to attend is here](#))
- Tuesday, April 28, 2026 (6:30–8:00 PM) ([Zoom link to attend is here](#))
- A recording of either information session is available upon request by emailing equity@austintexas.gov

Additional information, including registration details for these information sessions, will be available on the program website at austintexas.gov/equityminigrants.

Application Overview

The FY26 Equity Mini Grant application is designed to be clear, accessible, and focused on the most important aspects of community-based work. Applicants are not expected to use technical language or formal grant-writing frameworks. Clear, direct responses that reflect community knowledge and lived experience are encouraged.

How the Application is Organized

The application is divided into the following sections:

- **Section 1 – Eligibility Screening**
Basic questions to confirm eligibility requirements.
- **Section 2 – Organization and Contact Information**
General information about the applicant and, if applicable, fiscal sponsor.
- **Section 3 – Scored Questions**
Four required questions that will be evaluated as part of the review process.
- **Section 4 – Optional Background Information**
Additional context about the organization or project (not scored).
- **Section 5 – Bonus Question**
Identification of first-time City funding eligibility (+15 points).
- **Section 6 – Acknowledgements**
Confirmation of application accuracy and program requirements.

Scored vs. Unscored Sections

Only “Section 3 – Scored Questions” and the Bonus Question are used to determine application scores. Applicants are encouraged to focus the majority of their time and effort on the four scored questions. All other sections are used to:

- confirm eligibility;
- support administrative review;
- provide additional context.

Response Format Options

Applicants are not required to use formal or technical language. Responses should be clear, direct, and grounded in the applicant’s experience and knowledge of the community. Applicants may respond to questions in a format that best reflects their work and communication style. Accepted formats include:

- written responses;
- bullet points;
- short narratives.

Suggested Response Length

Stronger responses are typically specific and focused, clearly connected to community needs and planned in scope and implementation. Longer responses are not necessarily stronger. While there are no strict word limits, the following guidelines are recommended:

- Scored questions: approximately 200–600 words per question.
- Other sections: brief and direct responses.

Language Access and Translation

The program is committed to reducing language barriers and supporting equitable access to the application process. The application will be available in Spanish and English, and the submission of responses are supported in both languages. Applicants may request additional language access support by contacting equity@austintexas.gov.

APPLICATION QUESTIONS:

For questions or advisement on this application process, please contact:
equity@austintexas.gov

--

SECTION 1 – ELIGIBILITY (Required)

1.1 Will the work funded by this grant take place within Austin, Travis County, and the surrounding ETJ?

- Yes
- No
 - *If “No,” you are not eligible for this funding opportunity.*
 - *This program is funded by the City of Austin’s General Fund and supports activities that primarily serve communities within the City of*

Austin, Travis County, or the City's Extraterritorial Jurisdiction (ETJ).

1.2 Does your organization have an annual operating budget over \$500,000?

- No
- Yes
 - i. *If "Yes," please review and acknowledge the following funding preference.*
 - ii. *This funding opportunity is designed to prioritize small, grassroots, and community-driven initiatives that often lack access to flexible funding and professional grant-writing resources.*
 - iii. *Organizations with operating budgets above \$500,000 may still apply. However, depending on the applicant pool, preference may be given to organizations with operating budgets of \$500,000 or less and limited access to sustained funding.*

☐ *I understand and acknowledge this funding preference.*

1.3 Vendor Registration & Fiscal Sponsor Requirements:

To receive funding, all awardees must be registered as a vendor with the City of Austin.

Organizations that do not have 501(c)(3) non-profit status may:

- Apply with a fiscal sponsor who is required to register as a vendor with the city, or
- Register directly as an individual vendor and receive funds as taxable income. Individual vendors will receive a Form 1099 from the City of Austin.

In all cases, applicants must be prepared to complete vendor registration and be contract-ready *at the time of award, and no later than May 15, 2026*. Applicants who are not prepared to meet this requirement may be unable to complete the contracting process and may risk forfeiting the grant.

1.4 Are you (or your fiscal sponsor) able to meet this requirement?

- Yes
- No
 - *Applicants, and where applicable their fiscal sponsors, must be prepared to complete vendor registration and contracting requirements in order to receive funding.*

Please see the reference information below, and if you have any questions, please reach out to: equity@austintexas.gov

- [Vendor Registration Portal](#)
- [Step-by-Step Instructions \(PDF\)](#)
- [Vendor Services - General Overview](#)
- [ACH \(Direct Deposit\) Form](#) (Submit to vendor@austintexas.gov)
- For assistance, contact the Vendor Hotline at 512-974-2018 or email vendor@austintexas.gov.
- For general questions contact equity@austintexas.gov

--

SECTION 2 – ORGANIZATION & CONTACT INFO (Unscored)

2.1 Preferred language for communication:

(short answer)

2.2 Organization Name:

(short answer)

2.3 Project / Program / Proposal Name:

(short answer)

2.4 Mailing Address:

(short answer)

2.5 Website / Social Media:

(short answer)

2.6 Annual Operating Budget:

(short answer)

2.7 Is your organization a 501(c)(3)?

Yes,

No, (Applying with a fiscal sponsor),

No, (Applying as an individual/vendor and expect award as taxable income).

2.8 If applying with a fiscal sponsor, list the fiscal sponsor organization name and contact information (optional):

(short answer)

2.9 Primary Contact Name, Title, Phone, & Email:

(short answer)

2.10 Secondary Contact Name, Title, Phone, & Email (optional):

(short answer)

2.11 Organization General Email Intake (Optional):

(short answer)

2.12 Council District(s) primarily served: [Click here to find your council district](#)

(Select all that apply)

- District 1

- District 2
- District 3
- District 4
- District 5
- District 6
- District 7
- District 8
- District 9
- District 10
- Extraterritorial Jurisdiction (ETJ) – The ETJ is the unincorporated land within five miles of Austin's boundary that is not within the city limits.
- Travis County

2.13 Have you or your organization been awarded an Equity Mini Grant in the past?

(Yes, list year),

(No).

2.14 How did you hear about this funding opportunity?

(short answer)

--

SECTION 3 — SCORED QUESTIONS (Primary Evaluation Section)

Recommended 600-word limit.

3.1 Question #1 – Community Need & Context

What issue(s) affecting immigrant/refugee communities are you addressing and why is it important in Austin right now?

- *Please describe the community need your project responds to and how this need affects immigrant or refugee residents in Austin, Travis County, or the surrounding ETJ.*

(short answer)

3.2 Question #2 – The Work & Use of Funds

What work are you seeking funding for and how will funds be used?

- *Please describe the activities you plan to carry out and how grant funds will support this work.*
- *Projects that improve access to essential services, economic mobility, community stability, or opportunities for immigrant and refugee residents are strongly encouraged.*

(short answer)

3.3 Question #3 – Community Leadership

How are immigrants/refugees involved in leading, shaping, or evaluating this work?

- *Please describe how community members with lived experience help guide the work, including roles in leadership, program design, outreach, or evaluation.*

(short answer)

3.4 Question 4 – Relationships & Impact

How are you accountable to the community you serve? How do you understand and evaluate your impact?

- *Please describe the relationships you maintain with the community you work with and how you gather feedback, measure outcomes, or understand the impact of your work.*

(short answer)

--

SECTION 4 — OPTIONAL BACKGROUND (Unscored)

Use this space if you would like to share more about:

- Your organization's history
- Your motivation for this work
- Anything else you want reviewers to understand

(Optional — This section is not scored and is optional. Applicants are encouraged to focus their time on the four scored questions above.)

--

SECTION 5 — BONUS POINTS

First-Time City Funding (Automatic +15 points)

Have you ever been awarded a grant or contract or grant from the City of Austin?

- No (+15 points)
- Yes

--

SECTION 6 — ACKNOWLEDGEMENT

If selected, you agree:

- This application is for projects focused on Immigrant / Refugee Services.
- To participate in a program orientation.
- To complete a final report or evaluation summarizing the project outcomes.
- To host a site visit or participate in a virtual check-in with City staff.
- To respond in a timely manner to City staff communication throughout the program period (approximately 12–15 months).

☐ I Agree

--

Scoring Rubric and Review Process:

All applications will be evaluated through a competitive review process consistent with City of Austin procurement and grant administration requirements. Applications will be reviewed using the scoring rubric below. A diverse review panel will evaluate four scored questions worth a total of 100 points, with one additional automatic bonus question worth up to 15 points, for a maximum possible score of 115. The four scored questions appear first in the application to reduce burden and make expectations clear. The rubric is published so that applicants can understand how their responses will be evaluated.

--

SECTION 1 – EVALUATION OVERVIEW:

The rubric is published so that applicants can see exactly what reviewers are looking for, reflecting transparent and community-centered grantmaking practices that emphasize streamlined paperwork, clear expectations, and accessible participation for grassroots organizations.

How Applications Are Evaluated

The rubric reflects principles that value community knowledge and lived experience while supporting community-driven solutions that strengthen access to services, opportunity, and community well-being. These principles recognize grassroots leadership, flexible approaches to community work, and the understanding that impact can be demonstrated in multiple ways. Applicants are not required to use technical language, formal evaluation frameworks, or academic terminology. Reviewers will evaluate responses based on clarity, authenticity, connection to community, and the feasibility of the proposed work regarding four core elements:

1. community-defined need;
2. clear and responsible use of funds;
3. community leadership and lived expertise, and;
4. trust, accountability, and a realistic way to understand impact.

Professional grant writing, formal logic models, and complex evaluation plans are not required. Multiple forms of evidence—including stories, participation levels, learning

reflections, and numerical outcomes—are acceptable ways of demonstrating community knowledge and impact.

Safety and Confidentiality

Applicants **should not include personally identifying information** about community members, particularly information that could create risk for immigrants, refugees, or other vulnerable individuals. The program seeks to balance transparency with safety and does not expect applicants to disclose details that could place community members at risk.

Evaluation Process

The evaluation process will occur in the following stages:

1. *Eligibility Screening:*

City staff first screen all submitted applications to confirm eligibility requirements, including organizational eligibility, fiscal sponsorship documentation (if applicable), and completion of required application sections. Only eligible applications move forward to scoring.

2. *Independent Panel Review:*

Eligible applications are evaluated by a diverse review panel composed of individuals with knowledge and experience related to immigrant and refugee communities, community organizing, public service delivery, and social impact work. Panelists review applications independently and score each one using the standardized rubric.

3. *Panel Deliberation:*

After independent scoring, reviewers participate in a facilitated discussion to compare interpretations, ensure consistent application of the rubric, and reduce potential bias (consistent with City of Austin procurement and grant administration requirements). During this meeting, panelists may clarify their scoring decisions.

4. *Funding Recommendations:*

Following deliberation, the panel identifies the highest-scoring applications and develops awardee recommendations. These recommendations are then reviewed by City staff for administrative verification before final award decisions are made.

5. *Procurement Compliance:*

The evaluation process, scoring rubric, and award procedures are designed to comply with City of Austin purchasing and procurement requirements for

competitive funding opportunities. This structure supports transparency in decision-making, fair competition among applicants, and clear documentation of how funding decisions are made.

--

SECTION 2 – SCORING STRUCTURE:

Applications will be scored out of *100 total points* across four evaluation categories.

Category	Points
Community Need & Context	25
Proposed Work, Use of Funds, & Alignment with City Priorities	25
Community Leadership	25
Relationships & Impact	25

Bonus Points:

Category	Points
First-time City funding recipient	+15

Maximum possible score: **115**

Scoring Tiers: Each question is scored using the following six-tier scale. These tier descriptors are designed to provide consistent guidance for reviewers while recognizing the range of ways community organizations demonstrate leadership, knowledge, and impact. This program respects each applicant organization's dedicated efforts to improve the quality of life of our immigrant and refugee communities.

Score	Tier Label
5-10	Undeveloped

10-15	Weak
15-20	Emerging
20-22	Strong
23-25	Outstanding

How the Scoring Tiers Are Interpreted: These tiers are designed to balance responsible stewardship of public funds with accessible evaluation for community-rooted work.

- **5-10 Undeveloped**

The application does not provide enough information for reviewers to understand the proposed work or responsibly evaluate the use of public funds, or the response does not address the prompt.

- **10-15 Weak**

Responses at these levels often identify relevant ideas—such as community need, partnerships, or intended activities—but remain general or unclear about how the applicant knows the need exists, how the work will occur, or how the community is involved in shaping the effort.

- **15-20 Emerging**

This level represents a clear and credible response. The applicant provides sufficient information to understand the proposed work, see a plausible connection to community need, and understand how funds will be used. Professional grant writing or complex evaluation frameworks are not required to reach this level.

- **20-25 – Strong to Outstanding**

Higher scores recognize applications that demonstrate strong relationships, meaningful community leadership, and thoughtful accountability to the communities served. These responses typically show clear alignment between community need, proposed activities, and use of funds, while reflecting trust-centered practices such as community listening, shared decision-making, and responsible stewardship of resources.

Projects that demonstrate clear pathways to improving access to services, opportunity, community stability, or economic mobility for immigrant and refugee residents may also be reflected in higher scoring tiers.

SECTION 3 – RUBRIC:

Question 1 — Community Need & Context (25 points)

What we are trying to understand:

Whether the proposed work is responding to a *real, community-recognized need* in immigrant/refugee communities in Austin / Travis County / ETJ, and whether the applicant's understanding comes from lived experience, sustained relationship, and/or credible listening—not assumptions. This reflects the program's emphasis on community-informed understanding of local needs and solutions, and on engagement that is grounded in respectful and ongoing relationships.

Score	Tier label	Descriptor (what warrants this score)
5-10	Undeveloped / minimal context	The response does not describe a specific community issue or does not connect it to immigrant or refugee communities in Austin/Travis County/ETJ. Reviewers cannot determine what need is being addressed or why it matters. Names a broad issue (for example language barriers or access to services) but provides little local context and little explanation of who is most impacted or how the applicant knows the issue matters to the community.
10-15	Weak / generalized context	Describes a more specific issue and who it affects, but evidence/explanation of local conditions is limited (e.g., mostly generalized statements, or unclear why this issue is prioritized by the community served).
15-20	Emerging / community understanding	Clearly describes a specific community need, identifies who is most impacted, and provides a credible basis for how the applicant understands the issue (for example lived experience, ongoing work in the community, community conversations, partner insight, or recurring requests for support).
20-22	Strong / local grounding	Provides strong local grounding: names the local conditions/barriers shaping the issue (systems, policies, access constraints, safety, language, transportation, documentation concerns) and shows the need is recognized

		through ongoing relationships or listening with the community.
23-25	Outstanding / community-anchored insight	Demonstrates deep community-anchored understanding of the issue. The response reflects nuanced knowledge of local conditions and clearly shows that the applicant's understanding comes from sustained engagement, listening practices, or lived community experience, with attention to dignity and safety when describing community experiences.

Question 2 — The Work, Use of Funds, & Alignment with City Priorities (25 points)

What reviewers are trying to understand:

Whether the applicant can clearly account for how public dollars will be used to support the work that will happen. Reviewers are looking for a reasonable connection between the community need, the activities proposed, and how the funds will be spent. The work may include programs, events, services, operating support, or other community-based efforts. All of these are eligible uses of funds. The goal is to ensure public dollars are used responsibly while recognizing that community work can take many forms and that smaller or grassroots organizations may describe their work differently than larger nonprofits. Eligible uses of funds may include program activities, operating support, outreach, translation, event costs, supplies, or other expenses necessary to carry out community work.

Reviewers will also consider how the proposed work contributes to broader City of Austin priorities. These include strengthening community well-being, expanding access to essential services, supporting economic mobility, and building partnerships that improve quality of life for Austin residents. While applicants are not expected to use specific policy language, strong responses will demonstrate how their work helps remove barriers, expand opportunity, improve access to essential services, or strengthen community stability in ways that reflect broader City priorities, including economic mobility.

Score	Tier label	Evaluation Guidance (what warrants this score)
-------	------------	--

5-10	Undeveloped / minimal clarity in plan	The proposed work or use of funds is not described, or the response is too vague for the reviewer to determine what the grant would support. Mentions a general spending category (for example supplies, staffing, or program costs) but provides little explanation of what the funds will actually support or why those costs are necessary. The connection between the spending and the community need is unclear.
10-15	Weak / little specifics in plan	Provides some specifics (a few items or activities) but key details are missing how the work will happen, who will do it, or what the funding makes possible that otherwise would not occur.
15-20	Emerging / explains work plan	Clearly describes the proposed work and explains what the funds will pay for. The spending supports the activities described and the plan appears reasonable for the size and scope of the mini grant.
20- 22	Strong / implementation in plan	Shows strong alignment between need → strategy → spending: funds are clearly tied to essential activities or capacity. The response reflects realistic planning (e.g., sequencing, language access, outreach, or logistics) without overpromising.
23-25	Outstanding / community-responsive plan	Provides a transparent and grounded explanation of how funds will support the work. The applicant clearly explains why these costs matter for immigrant or refugee communities and demonstrates thoughtful stewardship of public funds while remaining flexible and responsive to community needs.

Question 3 — Community Leadership (25 points)

What reviewers are trying to understand:

Whether immigrants, refugees, or other directly impacted community members help shape decisions, priorities, and the design of the work. Reviewers are looking for evidence that lived experience informs leadership and/or that community members are involved in

meaningful ways beyond being recipients of services. The program prioritizes work that is guided by or developed with the people most affected by the issue. Community leadership may take many forms, including advisory roles, volunteer leadership, co-design, collaborative planning, or shared decision-making. These practices recognize that community knowledge and lived experience strengthen program design and responsiveness.

Score	Tier label	Evaluation Guidance (what warrants this score)
5-10	Undeveloped / community involvement	The response does not describe who makes decisions or how community members are involved. Reviewers cannot determine whether immigrants or refugees have any role in shaping the work. Immigrants or refugees are described mainly as participants, clients, or beneficiaries. There is little or no indication that they influence priorities, design, or decision-making.
10-15	Weak / community engagement	Indicates some community input (such as informal feedback, listening, or surveys), but the role of impacted community members in leadership or decision-making is limited or unclear.
15-20	Emerging / community advisory	Describes at least one clear way community members help shape the work. Examples may include advisory roles, community-led planning conversations, volunteer leadership, or co-design of activities.
20-22	Strong / shared community leadership	Demonstrates meaningful participation from directly impacted community members. Leadership roles or decision-making responsibilities are clearly described, and the applicant explains how feedback or community input influences the work.
23-25	Outstanding / community-led and includes power-sharing	Demonstrates clear and consistent community leadership in which decision-making is meaningfully shared with immigrant or refugee leaders. The response shows thoughtful attention to consent, language access, safety, and respectful representation, and describes how the organization centers community leadership and ensures

		community voices meaningfully shape priorities, strategies, and decisions.
--	--	--

Question 4 — Relationships & Impact (25 points)

What reviewers are trying to understand:

Whether the applicant demonstrates meaningful relationships and trust within immigrant or refugee communities and shows credible accountability to those communities.

Reviewers are also looking for a learning-oriented way the applicant understands the impact of their work that fits their context. Impact may be demonstrated through multiple forms of evidence, including stories, participation levels, community feedback, service outcomes, or quantitative data. Reviewers recognize that applicants may understand and document impact in ways that reflect their relationships and local context, rather than using formal evaluation systems. This approach reflects best practices of balancing accountability with learning, cultural responsiveness, and community-informed measures of success.

Score	Tier label	Descriptor (what warrants this score)
5-10	Underdeveloped / little or relationship evidence	The response does not describe relationships with the community or explain how the applicant will understand whether the work had an impact. Mentions community engagement or partnerships in passing but does not explain how trust is built/sustained or how impact will be understood.
10-15	Weak / unclear relationships	Describes some relationships with community members or partners and mentions possible ways impact might be measured, but accountability practices (such as listening, feedback, or reflection) are limited or unclear.
15-20	Emerging / describes community relationships	Clearly describes relationships with community members or partners and explains at least one meaningful way the organization understands its impact (for example participation levels, stories, feedback, changes in access, or service outcomes).

20-22	Strong / includes trust and accountability in relationships	Demonstrates strong community relationships and credible accountability. The response explains how trust is built over time, identifies relevant collaborations, and describes a realistic approach to learning from the work rather than simply reporting results.
23-25	Outstanding / deep trust and community-anchored impact	Demonstrates deep, sustained trust within the community and a thoughtful, learning-centered approach to understanding impact. The response shows accountability to community-defined success and describes feedback or reflection practices that shape the work while maintaining care for participant safety, dignity, and confidentiality.

Reviewer Guidance

This section provides guidance to support consistent, fair, and community-informed evaluation of applications and aligns with the City of Austin procurement and grant administration requirements. Reviewers are expected to apply the scoring rubric as written and to evaluate applications based on substance, not presentation style or formality of language.

Core Evaluation Approach

Applications should be evaluated on what is clearly communicated, not on writing style or level of polish. Reviewers will prioritize:

- clarity of the proposed work;
- connection to a defined community need;
- alignment between activities and use of funds;
- evidence of community relationships and lived experience.

Plain Language and Accessibility

Applicants are not required to use technical language, formal evaluation frameworks, or grant-writing conventions. Reviewers will:

- recognize that strong applications may be written in plain or conversational language;
- focus on whether the response demonstrates understanding, feasibility, and community connection.

Community Knowledge and Lived Experience

Community knowledge, lived experience, and sustained relationships are valid and important forms of expertise. Formal data, reports, or institutional credentials are not required to demonstrate credibility. Reviewers will value:

- direct experience with the community served;
- ongoing engagement or trust-based relationships;
- community-informed understanding of needs and priorities.

Consistency in Scoring

Scores should reflect the criteria described in the rubric, not personal preferences or external expectations. Reviewers are required to:

- disclose conflict of interest;
- agree/sign confidentiality forms;
- use the full range of the scoring scale & apply consistently across applications;
- participate in panel discussions to align scoring approaches.

Avoiding Bias

Reviewers should be aware of potential bias, including favoring larger or more established organizations, equating professionalism with impact, and prioritizing technical language over clarity. All applications should be evaluated on their ability to address a community-defined need, propose a feasible and responsive approach, and demonstrate connection(s) to the community served. This program is designed to support a diverse range of applicants, including grassroots, emerging, and community-led initiatives. Reviewers play a critical role in ensuring that the evaluation process remains fair, consistent, and aligned with the program's intent.

Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs)

1. Who can apply?

A wide range of applicants are eligible, including nonprofit organizations, grassroots groups, community collectives, faith-based organizations, and individuals.

The program prioritizes community-rooted work led by those with strong connections to the communities they serve.

2. What if I need help with the application?

The program is designed to be accessible, and support is available throughout the application period. Applicants may:

- attend office hours or information sessions
- contact the program team at equity@austintexas.gov

3. Do I need to be a nonprofit to apply?

No. Applicants do not need to be a 501(c)(3) nonprofit. Applicants must apply:

- as a registered City vendor, or
- through a fiscal sponsor.

4. What is a fiscal sponsor?

A fiscal sponsor is a tax-exempt organization that agrees to receive and manage funds on behalf of an applicant. Applicants who are not registered nonprofits may choose to work with a fiscal sponsor.

5. What can the funds be used for?

All expenses must support the proposed work described in the contracted scope of work. Funds may be used for a wide range of project-related expenses, including, but not limited to:

- program activities and services;
- outreach and community engagement;
- supplies and materials;
- translation and language access;
- events and workshops;
- stipends or operational support tied to the project.

6. What is the award amount?

Each selected applicant will receive a one-time award of **\$25,000**, through a competitive review process.

7. How will applications be evaluated?

After meeting eligibility requirements, there are four scored questions, each question is worth 25 points, for a total of 100 points, with an additional **+15 bonus points** for first-time City funding recipients. Applications are scored based on four questions:

- community need and context;
- proposed work and use of funds;
- community leadership;
- relationships and impact.

8. When will awards be announced?

Award notifications are expected in late May 2026, with contracting to occur in June 2026 and completing at the end of July 2026. Vendor registration (or fiscal sponsor readiness) must be completed **before a contract can be issued**. Applicants are strongly encouraged to begin this process as early as possible.

9. What happens if I am selected?

Selected applicants will:

- complete contracting requirements;
- participate in onboarding;

- finalize a scope of work;
- begin project implementation after contract execution.

10. When will funds be disbursed?

Funds will be disbursed after contract execution and the first invoice is submitted, in accordance with City payment processes. Awardees will receive guidance during onboarding on how to submit invoices.

11. What if I need language support?

Application materials will be available in English and Spanish. Applicants may also request additional language support by contacting the program team at equity@austintexas.gov. The entire application can be made available for submission in an alternate language if requested by email request.

12. Can I submit more than one application?

No. Only **one application per applicant or organization** will be accepted. Exceptions for those organizations that serve as fiscal sponsors for multiple community-led initiatives.